

TRIAD TACTICS

KLONDIKE

КЛОНДАЙК

THE KOLGUYEV CONCESSIONS

A PRIVATE WAR OVER THE DEVIL'S STONE

SEASON FORMAT: VAKHTA · FULL WIPE

ВАХТА

КОПИЯ · СОПУ

СОДЕРЖАНИЕ

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«Чёртов камень. Кидай в отвал.»

— shift foreman, Kolguyev mine, sometime in the 1970s

01

THE COUNTRY

РЕСПУБЛИКА БЕЛОМОРЬЕ

The **Republic of Belomorje** is a small state, one of the fragments of the Soviet Union. Kolguyev is its most distant island: a few hours by sea from the mainland, mining country since Soviet times.

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|-------------|--|
| 1991 | Independence with the collapse of the USSR. The republic inherits Kolguyev's mines, garrisons, and settlements it can barely afford to keep. |
| 1990s-2000s | The mines close one by one; the young leave for the mainland. The state's presence on the island shrinks to a port office, a post office, and one militia sergeant. |
| 2014-2018 | Civil war on the mainland. Four years of fighting produced no winner; with nothing left to fight with, the sides signed a ceasefire. The war never reached the island — it was simply forgotten. |
| 2018-2021 | The "reconstruction": foreign loans and two defaults. By 2021 the treasury is empty. |
| 2021-2022 | Kolguyevite is found on Kolguyev. The dispute over who may dig it does not stay legal for long. |

02

THE ISLAND

KOLGUYEV

Kolguyev — a dormant volcano, autumn taiga, old mine workings, settlements by the water.

UGOLDAR
SOUTH

The island's biggest town. When the shooting started in the west and center, nearly everyone still living in the other settlements moved here: it is safer, and there is work — the companies need housing, provisions, and hands. The town is neutral ground. Both companies keep their compounds here.

KAMENSK
NORTH-EAST

A garrison town for a submarine base. When the Union broke up the boats left and the base fell into decline; for a time the Belomorye navy's few ships were still serviced at its piers, but the unit was disbanded in the end. The buildings emptied and people began to leave. When kolguyevite was found, a black market formed in the half-empty town of its own accord, and civilian ships began putting in at the piers. Granit and Meridian look the other way, and now and then use the locals' services themselves.

THE VOLCANO
CENTER-WEST

Bare slopes; on the flanks, chains of hot pools with mineral crusts along their rims. The crust glints blue-green.

THE WORKINGS
WEST & CENTER

Adits, quarries, and conveyors of the closed mining kombinat. This is where the rock that holds kolguyevite has been laid open — and this is what the war is fought over.

THE SMALL ISLAND
SOUTH OF KOLGUYEV

The Belomorye army garrison — the last thing the state has left here.

03

THE DEVIL'S STONE

КОЛГУЕВИТ · ЧЁРТОВ КАМЕНЬ

Kolguevite — glassy blue-green crystals in the island's bedrock, deposited over millennia by the volcano's geothermal brines.

- 1968** Soviet mineralogists describe the crystal during routine surveying and name it after the locality. The scientists' conclusion: no industrial value.
- 1960s–1991** To the miners it is the rock that breaks drill bits and fouls furnaces. When it turns up in a seam, it goes out with the waste rock. Around here they call it **чёртов камень** — the devil's stone.
- 2021** Physicists studying superconductivity in natural minerals eventually get to kolguevite. It turns out to be a natural superconductor — a rare crystal structure. Materials with such properties are made in laboratories and cost more than gold; here the finished crystal lies in the ground.
- 2022** The only known deposit is Kolguev.

For half a century kolguevite was treated as waste rock. Today a gram of clean crystal is worth more than a miner here earned in a year.

THE CONCESSIONS

TWO LAWFUL OWNERS

The digging rights went first to **Granit Concern** — the way such questions had always been settled in Belomorje: in offices.

Half a year later the government fell. Street protests, snap elections — the opposition openly backed by the West. The new cabinet announced a review of the old licenses and granted extraction rights to **Meridian Group**. Granit's license was never actually revoked: the process sank in the courts.

So by law both companies hold the right to mine — and neither intends to yield.

КОНЦЕРН «ГРАНИТ»

An industrial conglomerate grown out of the Soviet mining industry; its capital comes from across the former Union. It brought old military hardware to the island, and men accustomed to undeclared wars.

MERIDIAN GROUP

A Western mining corporation: press releases about "responsible extraction", lawyers, contractors. On the island its interests are defended by hired guns.

The states behind the companies cannot afford to fight each other — so the fighting is left to hired men. Both corporations keep private military contractors recruited to the same pattern: ex-soldiers, easy-money chasers, criminals — people with nowhere to go back to. Officially they guard the mining sites. In practice they fight a war that never makes the news.

05

THE LOCALS

МЕСТНЫЕ

Nobody asked the islanders. A few thousand people: fishermen, former miners, and their families.

When the shooting started in the island's west and center, people moved to Ugoldar: it is safer there, and the companies pay well.

But neutrality is not obedience. The island is their home, and the foreign war is a living. Some work as guides, some trade, and some go out to the workings at night and come back carrying. The black market takes everything — stolen kolguyevite, weapons, gear stripped from the dead. In Ugoldar it is bought quietly; in Kamensk it is sold back, most often to the same companies.

THE GARRISON

АРМИЯ БЕЛОМОРЬЯ

The Belomorye army holds the small island south of Kolguyev. It cannot expel the companies: the licenses are genuine, and the republic has nothing to fight two private armies with.

But the presence turned out to be profitable. Both companies pay the state for extraction — and pay the army command separately: for clearances, and for patrols that happen to be elsewhere at the right time. For the army command this conflict is the best thing to happen in all their years of service.

Nobody touches the Garrison: everyone needs it exactly as it is.

07

THE ISLAND KEEPS IT

BAXTA

Grey dawns, wet concrete, rusted cranes against a white sky. There are no heroes here: everyone came for the money, and everyone suspects the money will stay with the island.

Work on Kolguyev runs in shifts — the season here is simply called the **Vakhta** (БАХТА). You fly in, you work your shift, you fly out. The island stays — and waits for the next shift.

The old men spent their lives throwing this stone away.

Now people kill for it.

The old men say: so we were right to throw it.

КОНЕЦ ДЕЛА · END OF FILE